

WOMEN

LADIES FIRST

Boasting of the highest number of women MPs ever, the 15th Lok Sabha marks the dawn of a new era in Parliament

Politicians could manage to block the Women's Reservation Bill, but the nation has voted the largest-ever contingent of women to Parliament. The representation of women has crossed 10 per cent for the first time, bringing in a line-up of fresh faces. Meenakshi Natrajan's election from Mandsaur in the prosperous poppy-growing belt says something about the catholicity of the worldview of the voters as much as her own grit to take on BJP veteran Laxmi Narayan Pandey who had won the constituency six times in a row. Handpicked by Rahul Gandhi as All India Congress Committee secretary, the Tamil Brahmin won from a constituency deep in the heart of the Malwa region of Madhya Pradesh where you would struggle to find a sizeable Brahmin population, let alone that of Tamil origin. Adding a dash of stardust to the House is Vijaya Shanthi who made her screen magic work in Medak constituency of Andhra Pradesh. Also topping the list is Shruti Choudhry, granddaughter of former Haryana chief minister Bansi Lal. "It's a serious job. I just have to do it," she says. In the 2004 elections, 45 women won the polls; this time the number has gone up to 59, ten more than the previous best of 49 in the 13th Lok Sabha. Looks like it's a humble beginning of the women's era.

PERCENTAGE OF WOMEN MEMBERS IN LOK SABHA

LOK SABHA	YEAR	PERCENTAGE OF WOMEN MEMBERS
1	1952	4.4%
2	1957	4.5%
3	1962	6.7%
4	1967	5.8%
5	1971	4.9%
6	1977	3.8%
7	1980	5.7%
8	1985	7.9%
9	1989	5.2%
10	1991	7.6%
11	1996	7.4%
12	1998	8.1%
13	1999	9.2%
14	2004	8.7%
15	2009	10.7%

Source: PRS Legislative Research

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SIPRA DAS



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REUBEN SINGH



TIRBHUVAN TIWARI

SUPRIYA SULE
Maharashtra,
Baramati **NCP**

MEENAKSHI NATRAJAN
Madhya Pradesh,
Mandsaur **INC**

DEEPA DASMUNSI
West Bengal,
Raiganj **INC**

HARSIMRAT KAUR
Punjab,
Bhatinda **SAD**

VIJAYA SHANTHI
Andhra Pradesh,
Medak **TRS**